

Variable Research: Adverse – Household Dysfunction (2023 National YRBS Dataset)

QN89

Verbal/emotional abuse by a household adult

Codebook label: “Percentage of students who reported that a parent or other adult in their home most of the time or always insulted them or put them down (during their life)”

This variable captures frequent childhood verbal abuse, a form of emotional maltreatment strongly linked to adolescent suicidality. A meta-analysis of longitudinal studies found that emotional abuse significantly increased the risk of subsequent suicidal ideation and attempts, with odds ratios often ranging from 1.5 to over 3.0 (Liu et al., 2017). In youth samples, repeated verbal hostility from caregivers is associated with low self-esteem, depression, and perceived burdensomeness - key drivers of suicidal thoughts and behaviours. Including QN89 as an adverse household dysfunction indicator is well-supported by the ACE literature.

- Liu J, Fang Y, Gong J, et al. (2017). *Associations between childhood emotional abuse and later suicidal behaviors: A meta-analysis*. Trauma, Violence, & Abuse, 18(5), 552-567. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1524838016663938>
- Miller AB, Esposito-Smythers C, Weismore JT, Renshaw KD. (2013). *The relation between child maltreatment and adolescent suicidal behavior: A systematic review and critical examination of the literature*. Clinical Child and Family Psychology Review, 16(2), 146-172. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10567-013-0131-5>

QN90

Physical abuse by a household adult

Codebook label: “Percentage of students who reported that a parent or other adult in their home most of the time or always hit, beat, kicked, or physically hurt them in any way (during their life)”

Frequent physical abuse is one of the most potent ACEs for adolescent suicidality. Systematic reviews consistently find that youth exposed to physical abuse are two to three times more likely to report suicidal ideation and attempts than non-abused peers,

even after adjusting for mental health conditions (Miller et al., 2013; Norman et al., 2012). The neurobiological stress of repeated physical harm, combined with feelings of fear and betrayal, erodes coping resources and fosters hopelessness, making QN90 a critical adverse variable in any co-occurrence analysis.

- Miller AB et al. (2013). *ibid*.
- Norman RE, Byambaa M, De R, et al. (2012). *The long-term health consequences of child physical abuse, emotional abuse, and neglect: A systematic review and meta-analysis*. PLoS Medicine, 9(11), e1001349. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pmed.1001349>

QN91

Domestic violence in the home

Codebook label: “Percentage of students who reported that their parents or other adults in their home most of the time or always slapped, hit, kicked, punched, or beat each other up (during their life)”

Witnessing intimate partner violence between adults in the home is a severe adverse experience that threatens a child’s sense of safety. The original ACE Study found that exposure to domestic violence substantially increased the risk of lifetime suicide attempts (Felitti et al., 1998), and more recent adolescent-focused research confirms a strong association with suicidal ideation and attempts (Hughes et al., 2017). The chronic stress of living in a violent home may impair emotion regulation and normalise aggression, including self-directed violence.

- Felitti VJ et al. (1998). *Relationship of childhood abuse and household dysfunction to many of the leading causes of death in adults*. Am J Prev Med, 14(4), 245-258. [https://doi.org/10.1016/S0749-3797\(98\)00017-8](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0749-3797(98)00017-8)
- Hughes K et al. (2017). *The effect of multiple adverse childhood experiences on health: a systematic review and meta-analysis*. Lancet Public Health, 2(8), e356-e366. [https://doi.org/10.1016/S2468-2667\(17\)30118-4](https://doi.org/10.1016/S2468-2667(17)30118-4)

QN100

Parental/guardian substance abuse

Codebook label: “Percentage of students who ever lived with a parent or guardian who was having a problem with alcohol or drug use”

Living with a caregiver who misuses alcohol or drugs is a classic ACE. In the ACE Study, household substance abuse was independently associated with a 2- to 3-fold increase in the odds of a lifetime suicide attempt (Felitti et al., 1998). Large meta-analyses confirm that parental alcohol and drug problems are robustly linked to adolescent suicidal thoughts, plans, and attempts, with effects persisting after controlling for sociodemographic factors (Hughes et al., 2017). The chronic unpredictability and family conflict typical of substance-abusing households likely increase feelings of hopelessness and emotional dysregulation.

- Felitti VJ et al. (1998). *ibid.*
- Hughes K et al. (2017). *ibid.*

QN101

Parental/guardian mental illness or suicidality

Codebook label: “Percentage of students who ever lived with a parent or guardian who had severe depression, anxiety, or another mental illness, or was suicidal”

This item captures household exposure to both chronic mental illness and acute suicidal behaviour, a combination of genetic vulnerability, environmental modelling, and emotional contagion. In the ACE Study, household mental illness roughly doubled the odds of a lifetime suicide attempt (Felitti et al., 1998). Using previous YRBS cycles, Baiden et al. (2021) found that living with a mentally ill or suicidal household member was one of the strongest household-level predictors of suicidal ideation, plans, and attempts among high-school students. Because the question explicitly includes “or was suicidal,” it captures a particularly severe exposure that may normalise self-harm.

- Felitti VJ et al. (1998). *ibid.*
- Baiden P et al. (2021). *Examining the association between adverse childhood experiences and suicidal ideation, plans, and attempts among a national sample*

of US adolescents. J Sch Health, 91(2), 120-130. <https://doi.org/10.1111/josh.12985>

QN102

Separation due to parental incarceration

Codebook label: “Percentage of students who have ever been separated from a parent or guardian because they went to jail, prison, or a detention center”

This variable captures the child’s direct experience of losing a caregiver to incarceration, a severe attachment disruption. Meta-analytic evidence shows that parental incarceration is significantly associated with elevated rates of mental health problems in children, including suicidal thoughts and self-harm (Murray et al., 2012). The combination of stigma, financial strain, and reduced supervision likely intensifies hopelessness. In the YRBS, QN102 is expected to co-occur strongly with suicide-related outcomes, and it offers a more proximal measure of separation than a simple “household member ever incarcerated” item.

- Murray J, Farrington DP, Sekol I. (2012). *Children's antisocial behavior, mental health, drug use, and educational performance after parental incarceration: A systematic review and meta-analysis*. Psychol Bull, 138(2), 175-210. <https://doi.org/10.1037/a0026407>
- Geller A et al. (2012). *Beyond absenteeism: Father incarceration and child development*. Demography, 49(1), 49-76. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s13524-011-0068-3>